

Anthony Davis in Washington: A Buy-Low Bet on Top-75 Talent

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Executive Summary

Anthony Davis is a top-75 player of all time and, when healthy, has still played at a borderline top-10 level over the past half-decade. Availability remains the concern: he's appeared in just 279 of 456 possible games (61.2%) over the last six seasons, including 71 of 134 (53%) over the last two years.

Injuries (some unlucky, some cumulative) have pushed Davis to the lowest market value of his career, compounded by unrealistic expectations that asked him to carry a young roster and replace a franchise's former all-time great.

In Washington, Davis finally slots into his preferred role at the four alongside Alex Sarr, forming a high-upside defensive frontcourt behind a young core and a Trae Young-led backcourt. He still provides elite rim pressure, defensive versatility, and play-finishing value when used to amplify strengths rather than force self-creation.

For the Wizards, Davis's value lies in accelerating their competitive timeline. He adds reliable rim pressure, creates defensive havoc through elite disruption, and brings structure to a roster that will naturally be volatile. If it works, Washington gains an elite two-way presence; if it doesn't, the downside can be washed away in the near future.

Overview

\begin{table}[!h] \caption{Anthony Davis: Season Splits (2020-21 to 2025-26) - TS% and rTS% vs league}

Season	GP	MPG	FGM-FGA	FG%	3PM-3PA	3P%	FTM-FTA	FT%	REB	AST	STL	BLK	PF	TOV	PTS	TS%	League TS%	rTS%
2020-21	36	32.3	8.4-17.0	49.1%	0.7-2.8	26.0%	4.4-5.9	73.8%	7.9	3.1	1.3	1.6	1.7	2.1	21.8	55.6%	57.2%	-1.6%
2021-22	40	35.1	9.3-17.4	53.2%	0.3-1.8	18.6%	4.4-6.1	71.3%	9.9	3.1	1.2	2.3	2.4	2.1	23.2	57.8%	56.6%	1.2%
2022-23	56	34.0	9.7-17.2	56.3%	0.3-1.3	25.7%	6.2-7.9	78.4%	12.5	2.6	1.1	2.0	2.6	2.2	25.9	62.6%	58.1%	4.5%
2023-24	76	35.5	9.4-16.9	55.6%	0.4-1.4	27.1%	5.5-6.8	81.6%	12.6	3.5	1.2	2.3	2.3	2.1	24.7	62.1%	58.0%	4.1%
2024-25	51	33.4	9.2-17.8	51.6%	0.7-2.4	28.2%	5.6-7.2	77.5%	11.6	3.5	1.2	2.2	1.9	2.2	24.7	58.9%	57.6%	1.3%
2025-26	20	31.3	8.5-16.7	50.6%	0.5-1.9	27.0%	3.0-4.1	72.8%	11.1	2.8	1.1	1.7	2.1	2.1	20.4	55.1%	58.0%	-2.9%

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Over the past five seasons, Davis has hovered around 24 points per game on great efficiency, strong rebounding, elite defensive playmaking, but the year-to-year story is shows that his production can be hindered by minutes and health. That volatility shows up in swings in both scoring and efficiency relative to league-average TS%. Davis is most effective when he's attacking the rim and drawing fouls, and that shows up across his best seasons in recent years.

Offense: Playtypes

Playtype Table

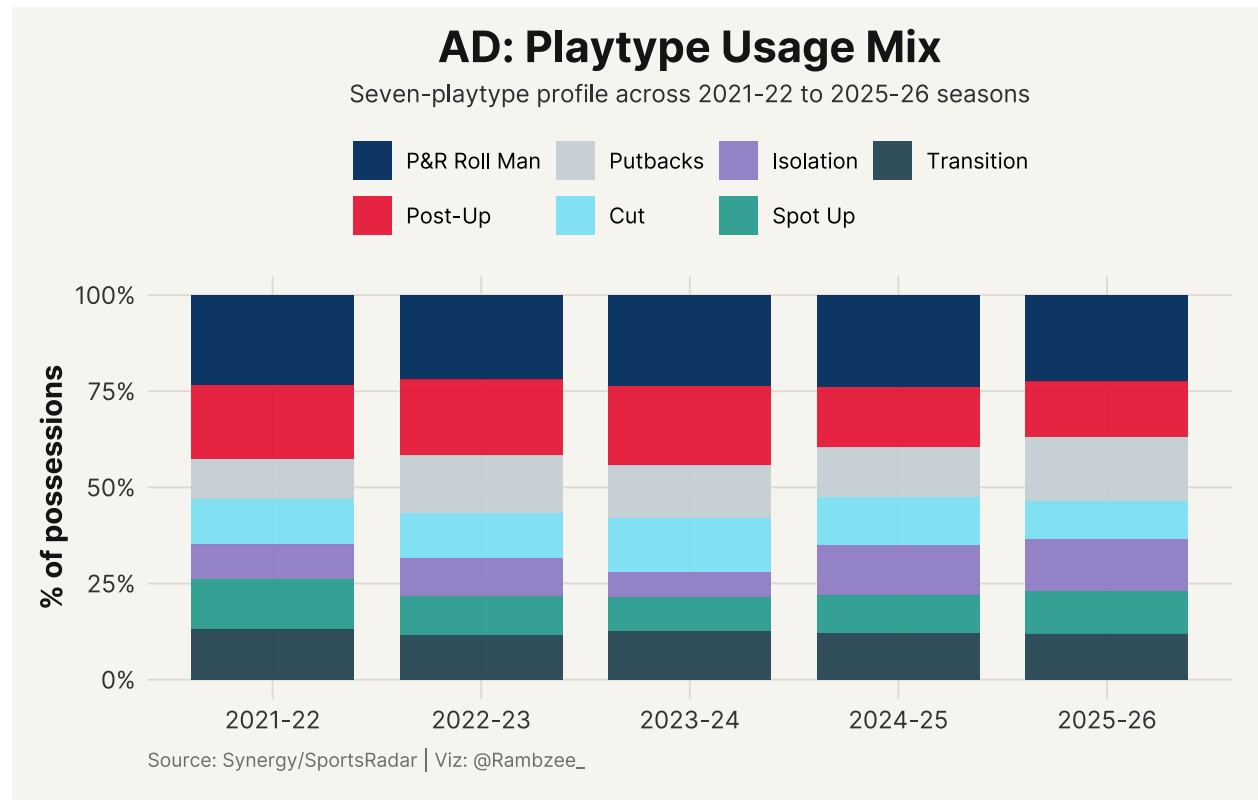
Davis' offense is at its best in traditional big-man roles. As a roller, cutter, offensive rebounder, and post-up threat, he produces strong volume and efficiency, averaging over 1.0 PPP across those actions. His offensive rebounding, in particular, remains a major advantage.

Table 1: Anthony Davis: Featured Playtypes (possession-weighted summary)

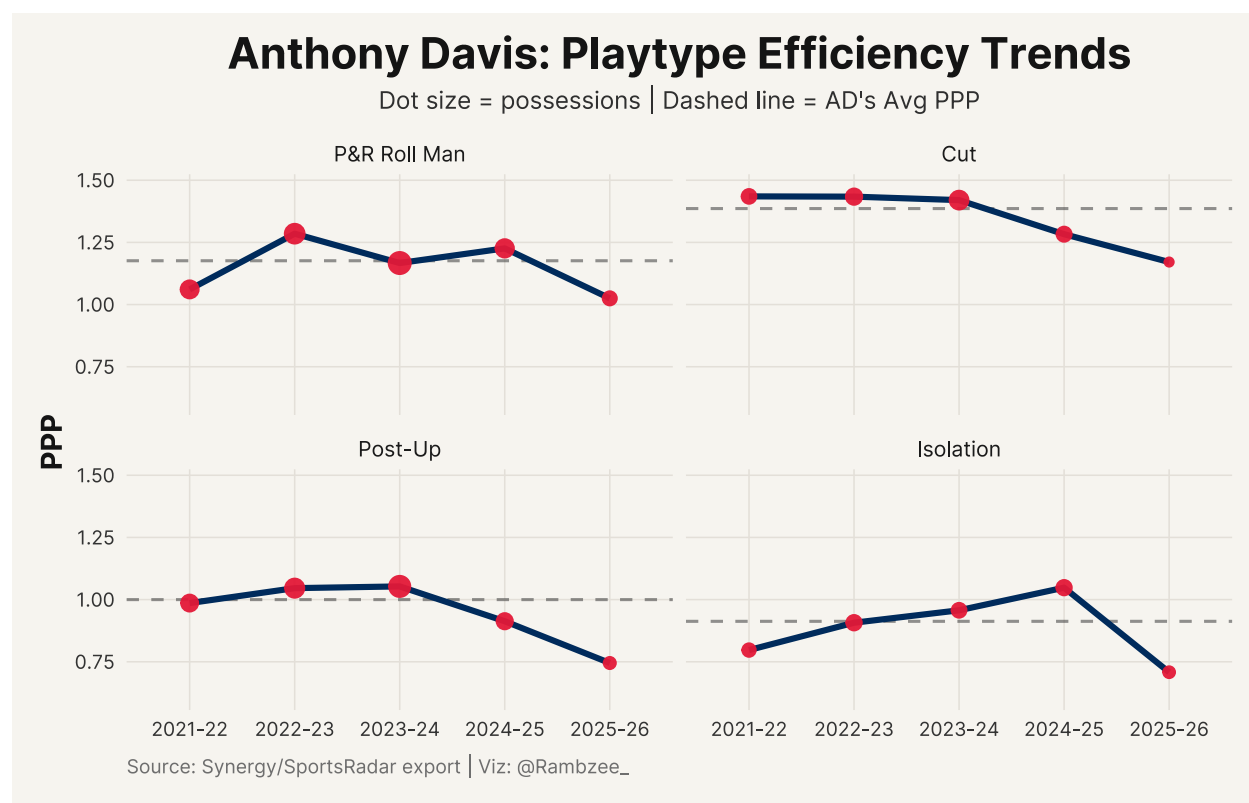
play_type	Seasons	Poss	Avg %Time	Avg PPP	Avg PPP Rank	Avg PPP Rating
P&R Roll Man	5	1033	19.8%	1.176	62	Very Good
Post-Up	5	842	16.4%	1.000	59	Very Good
Putbacks	5	603	11.8%	1.287	79	Very Good
Cut	5	562	10.9%	1.386	68	Very Good
Transition	5	553	10.6%	1.255	74	Very Good
Spot Up	5	455	8.9%	0.800	17	Poor
Isolation	5	423	8.6%	0.913	55	Good

His limitations show up as a perimeter scorer. Davis ranks in just the 17th percentile on spot-ups, struggles to consistently punish closeouts, and is good, but not great, in isolation outside the post. That profile fits Washington well, as it doesn't require him to be a primary creator; his value comes from being a pressure point through screens, seals, short rolls, and mismatches.

Usage mix

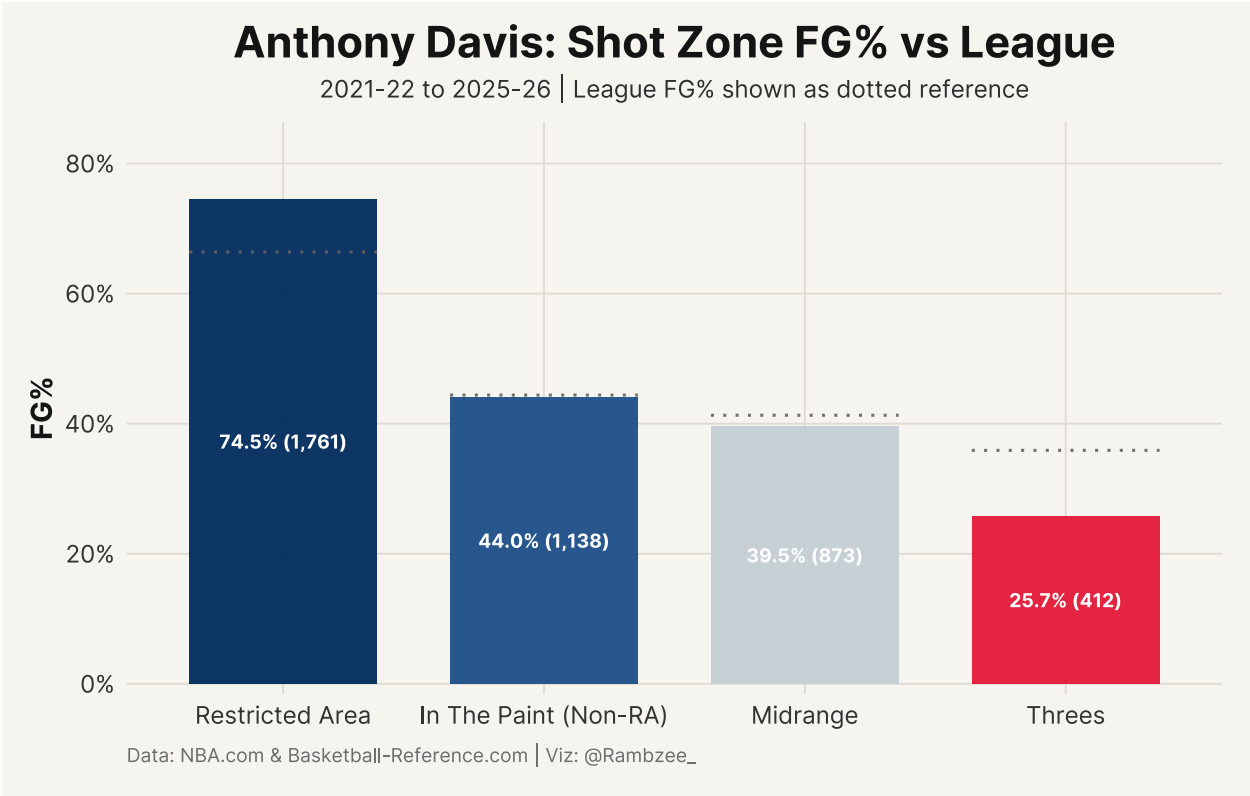


PPP trends



Davis is most consistent as a cutter and roll man, where his efficiency remains strong year to year. His post-up scoring has softened somewhat, and isolation dipped this season in limited time. When his offense is driven by movement and rim pressure it's at its best; when it shifts toward self-creation, it becomes less efficient, though he remains an good scorer overall.

Shot Zones: AD vs League FG%



Davis is a top-tier finisher at the rim and he remains effective in the paint as a counter when he can't get all the way to the basket. As his shot diet drifts to the midrange or beyond the arc, the efficiency drop becomes clear. He can take those shots when needed, but his offense is at its best when he's living near the rim and forcing defenses to respond to his size and touch rather than settling for jumpers.

Defensive Profile

Table 2: Anthony Davis: Stocks per game ranks (STL+BLK) — min 20 GP, min 15 MPG

Season	Team	GP	MPG	STL	BLK	Stocks/G	Rank	Pctile
2021-22	LAL	40	35.1	1.2	2.3	3.5	1 / 343	100.0%
2022-23	LAL	56	34.0	1.1	2.0	3.1	3 / 323	99.4%
2023-24	LAL	76	35.5	1.2	2.3	3.5	2 / 316	99.7%
2024-25	DAL	51	33.4	1.2	2.2	3.4	3 / 340	99.4%
2025-26	WAS	20	31.3	1.1	1.7	2.8	4 / 310	99.0%

Stocks per game is a simple but effective way to capture defensive event creation, and it highlights one of Davis's most dependable strengths. When healthy, he has consistently ranked near the top of the league in combined steals and blocks, using elite hands and defensive awareness to create extra possessions.

For a young Washington team, the margins matter even more. Defensive events fuel transition opportunities, cover for mistakes, and reduce the need for perfect half-court execution. Pairing Davis with Alex Sarr, who brings similarly strong stocks production (3.7 per game), gives the Wizards a frontcourt capable of turning disruption into easy points.

Since 2021, Davis ranks second in the NBA in stocks per game, highlighting just how rare his defensive

Table 3: NBA Stocks Leaders (STL + BLK per game), Last 5 Seasons

Rank	Player	Stocks/G	BLK/G	STL/G	GP	MPG	PPG	RPG	APG	TS%
1	Victor Wembanyama	4.57	3.4	1.1	155	30.5	22.9	10.9	3.5	58.7%
2	Anthony Davis	3.31	2.2	1.2	243	34.3	24.4	11.8	3.2	60.3%
3	Jaren Jackson Jr.	3.10	2.0	1.1	327	29.5	19.7	5.9	1.6	57.2%
4	Walker Kessler	2.85	2.4	0.5	201	25.3	9.5	9.3	1.2	67.9%
5	Chet Holmgren	2.83	2.2	0.6	160	29.0	16.6	8.2	2.1	63.2%

impact remains even as he enters the later stages of his career. Built on elite instincts, timing, and still-high-level athleticism, his value shows up not just in rim protection but in consistently driving strong team defense.

\begin{table}[!h] \caption{Anthony Davis: Rim protection at the rim (<6 ft) - DFG% vs Expected}

Season	Defended Att	DFG%	Exp%	Diff
2021-22	281	56.6%	63.5%	-6.9%
2022-23	394	58.9%	65.5%	-6.6%
2023-24	576	56.4%	63.8%	-7.4%
2024-25	332	52.1%	64.4%	-12.3%
2025-26	120	55.0%	64.3%	-9.3%

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The rim data highlights Davis’s value as an anchor. Opponents consistently shoot worse than expected at the rim when he’s the primary defender. Pairing him with Alex Sarr only amplifies that impact. Sarr brings his own rim protection (2.1 BPG and a strong -9.1% rim FG differential), giving Washington flexibility. Davis can handle bigger centers while Sarr roams as a backline defender, or the two can switch against quicker bigs. Together, they give the Wizards a frontcourt that can erase mistakes and control the paint.

Fit in Washington

Table 4: Washington young core (as provided) — context for AD fit

Player	Age	Pos	MPG	PTS	TRB	AST	3P%	3PA	STL	BLK	TOV
Trae Young	27	PG	34.3	25.2	3.5	9.8	35.1%	7.5	1.0	0.2	4.2
Kyshawn George	22	SF	30.6	15.1	5.5	4.9	37.6%	5.6	1.1	0.9	2.8
Alex Sarr	20	C	28.3	17.3	7.7	2.8	33.9%	3.0	0.8	2.1	1.7
Bub Carrington	20	PG	28.2	10.1	3.6	4.6	40.2%	5.3	0.6	0.2	2.4
Bilal Coulibaly	21	SG	26.6	9.7	4.6	2.6	26.2%	3.3	1.4	0.9	1.5
Tre Johnson	19	SG	25.1	12.9	2.7	2.2	39.3%	5.5	0.6	0.3	1.4

Defense: Raising the Floor and Aiding the Young Guys

With a young core and a bad defensive backcourt, you’re going to have blown coverages and late help. AD reduces the cost of those mistakes by turning rim attempts into tougher finishes and by creating extra possessions through blocks/steals. That gives Washington margin while their defensive habits develop.

With Sarr

This is the most interesting pairing. Sarr’s tools (length, mobility, and rim protection) allow him to play as a roaming “eraser,” while Davis can take the more physical matchups and serve as the primary anchor. That dynamic is flexible. Against bruising centers, AD handles the strength while Sarr operates as an elite weakside deterrent; against quicker bigs and five-out lineups, the two can switch more actions and still recover at the rim. Either way, it’s a frontcourt built to cover ground and mask perimeter breakdowns, especially when Trae is targeted defensively.

With Kyshawn + Bilal

These two are promising defensive wings. If Kyshawn continues to grow as a bigger, switchable wing and Bilal maintains his disruptive point-of-attack defense, the AD-Sarr pairing gives them a strong backline to play more aggressively. That support allows the wings to press, gamble selectively, and use their length to create advantages. Whether Washington reaches a top-15 defense will likely hinge on how well those wings, and the rest of the perimeter group, can consistently hold up.

With Trae + Bub

Trae will always be a defensive stress point. Even with effort, the small-guard tax is hard to escape, and Bub faces similar issues as he continues to learn physicality and positioning. This is where AD's size and mobility matter most, reducing how often guards are left on an island. When they are the primary defender, the task becomes funneling drives, buying time, and fighting as hard as they can to turn rim attempts into pull-ups instead of easy finishes.

Offense: Simplify, Add Stability, and Relieve Pressure

Washington doesn't need AD to carry the offense or create everything himself. They need him to be a steady interior force that bends the defense. With four of their six core players shooting 35% or better from three and Sarr close behind at 34%, there is enough shooting to punish help and keep the floor functional. There is still room for growth, but the surrounding spacing should be sufficient to maximize Davis's impact in the paint.

Trae + AD

Trae's gravity paired with AD's screening and rolling should quickly become the backbone of Washington's offense. Even without elite spacing, that two-man game forces rotations, creates rim pressure, and opens kick-out reads for young wings. AD also serves as a dependable release valve (lobs, short rolls, seals, and post touches) so possessions don't stall when defenses switch or navigate screens well.

Sarr's development

If Sarr develops into a credible floor-spacer, it unlocks AD at the four in his preferred role and keeps the lane cleaner for rim pressure. Early on, the two can be staggered to maintain spacing and rim presence; long term, Sarr's shooting is what makes the pairing seamless. Even if the window is only a few seasons, playing alongside an elite interior scorer like AD could accelerate Sarr's offensive development.

Kyshawn + Tre

Both benefit from the attention Davis commands. Kyshawn should see more catch-and-shoot looks and cleaner driving lanes, letting him lean into his growth as a secondary creator against tilted defenses. Tre gains easier shot opportunities as a movement shooter and a reliable screen partner if his on-ball reps increase in Trae-out minutes. Beyond spacing, AD's screening is impactful. Across staggers, flares, zipper cuts, and other off-ball actions, Davis's screening strength forces defenders to navigate real contact rather than slip cleanly over the top. That physical toll creates consistent separation, turning marginal windows into clean catches and freeing shooters for a handful of extra quality looks each game.

Overall: A Buy-Low Bet

Anthony Davis is an expensive name, but the actual cost was relatively modest. Washington gave up players and picks they had minimal regard for in long term and, in return, added a borderline top-10 talent without tying their future to him. If the fit works, they gain elite two-way production. If it doesn't, they can move on without damaging the core, either by letting him walk or absorbing a short late-career overpay.

The move fits the Trae Young approach. Buy low on elite talent, reduce expectations, and see what a new environment can unlock alongside a young roster. This may not be the future Davis once imagined, but it gives him a clear role as a stabilizing veteran and tone-setter, similar to the bridge LeBron once provided for him.